



Dream with Dan September 15

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XyjQ4Ll1_RI
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Municipal Meeting Summary Report

Meeting: Muncie Neighborhood Association & "Dream with Dan" Town Hall

Location: Minnetrista (North of McKinley Neighborhood), Muncie, Indiana

Participants: Mayor Dan Ridenour, HR Director Micah, City Controller Craig Wright, Neighborhood President Bruce Rector, and McKinley neighborhood residents.

1. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** Mayor Dan Ridenour called the combined neighborhood meeting and "Dream with Dan" session to order [00:00:08](#), broadcasting updates from city officials and taking questions from residents.
- **Attendance:**
 - **Presiding Officer:** Mayor Dan Ridenour [00:00:08](#)
 - **Board Members/Staff Present:** Micah (HR Director) [00:00:11](#); Craig Wright (City Controller) [00:00:22](#); Bruce Rector (McKinley Neighborhood President) [00:00:36](#).

2. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting took place following a neighborhood association gathering at Minnetrista [00:00:28](#). No formal roll call or invocations were recorded in this

community forum setting.

- **Approval of Minutes:** Not applicable (informational town hall format).
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3. Substantive Business & Board Action

Note: This session focused on municipal updates, administrative reports, and community Q&A rather than formal legislative voting. No roll-call or voice votes on ordinances occurred during this transcript.

- **00:01:08 Economic Development & Infrastructure Updates**

- **Presenter:** Mayor Dan Ridenour

- **Deliberation Summary:**

- *Gilman Home Center:* Nearing opening on the south side; delayed temporarily due to merchandise inventory supply chain challenges.
 - *Southway Plaza (Markets on Madison):* Phase 1 of parking lot demolition is complete, seeded, and growing grass. Parking lot will be reduced to half its original size. Designed with a small pond, walking paths, and greenery as an entryway into the city. Brick Red Systems (Seattle software firm) is locating there and hiring its first 50 employees.
 - *Hotel Study:* Commissioned via Muncie Redevelopment Commission (MRC) to identify east-side locations (near East Jackson, East Memorial, and the bypass) to support new manufacturing facilities.
 - *YMCA Acquisition:* MRC approved purchasing the current YMCA building to aid their fundraising for a new facility; the city will lease it back temporarily with no city expense.

- **Action & Disposition:** Informational report; no formal vote required.

- **00:06:26 Parks and Recreation Updates**

- **Presenter:** Mayor Dan Ridenour

- **Deliberation Summary:**

- *Riverview Park:* Construction underway for a splash pad, safer parking, ADA-compliant restrooms, shelter upgrades, and playgrounds (some equipment delayed to spring due to supply chains). Developed after 7<U+2013>8 neighborhood meetings.
 - *Other Parks:* Tuhey Park swimming pool equipment and playground repairs underway; Jack's Park basketball court redone with pickleball/basketball lines and planned playground equipment; Morningside Park improvements continuing.
 - *West Side Park Skate Park:* Being engineered near Tillotson and White River Boulevard following a 491-response survey from the skater community. Construction slated for next year.

- **Action & Disposition:** Informational report; no formal vote required.
 - **00:10:16 Human Resources Department Update**
 - **Presenter:** Micah, HR Director
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Department consists of 3 staff members handling personnel, compliance, seasonal hires, and Muncie Sanitary District (MSD) HR advisory functions.
 - Ongoing partnerships with Shaping Leadership for training (conflict resolution, ethics, diversity, DOT supervisor certifications).
 - Current city staffing: 463 total employees (339 full-time, 102 part-time, 12 elected officials), plus 145 MSD employees and 151 active police/fire pensioners.
 - Open positions include Animal Control part-time, Prairie Creek Reservoir seasonal labor, Police Victim Advocate, Deputy City Clerk, and various MSD technical roles.
 - **Action & Disposition:** Informational report; no formal vote required.
 - **00:16:34 City Controller Financial & Budget Update**
 - **Presenter:** Craig Wright, City Controller
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Managed via a tenured staff and Deputy Controller Matt Wagley.
 - Explained the annual budget process: collaboration with the Department of Local Government Finance (DLGF) to set tax rates and levies; preparing budget estimates (Form 1) based on 6-month performance reports.
 - Mandated 2% across-the-board raises negotiated with three unions (Fire, Police, AFSCME). Fuel costs increased by 20% due to inflation.
 - City council reviews the budget across three public sessions; council can cut or shift funds *within* the same fund (e.g., General Fund 101, Parks Fund 200 series) but cannot add overall appropriations or move money between separate funds.
 - Noted high fixed operational costs, such as traffic light electricity (\$40,000/month average).
 - **Action & Disposition:** Informational report; no formal vote required.
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4. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- **00:25:00 Resident (Unnamed):** Inquired about restroom vandalism at city parks. Mayor Ridenour acknowledged challenges with vandalism and discussed utilizing neighborhood watch and security cameras.
- **00:27:11 Resident (Unnamed):** Expressed excitement over the popularity of pickleball and outdoor recreation. Mayor Ridenour highlighted court conversions at Jack's Park and other locations.

- **00:32:04 Resident (Unnamed) 00:33:09:** Raised concerns that low home property values in the McKinley neighborhood make home improvement financing and loans difficult for longtime homeowners.
 - *Response:* Mayor Ridenour and HR Director Micah noted that new infill construction will raise appraised values, tax sale properties have dropped by 80% to 90%, and federal lending restrictions (originating from Dodd-Frank) impact older home refinancing.
- **00:41:48 Resident (Unnamed):** Asked about the status of an MRC-owned vacant lot next to their property slated for building.
 - *Response:* Mayor Ridenour indicated previous plans fell through, leaving the lot open for a new private home build.
- **00:44:39 Resident (Unnamed):** Noted issues with poison ivy and overgrowth on a city-owned vacant lot on East Columbus.
 - *Response:* Mayor Ridenour promised to check with the Building Commissioner.
- **00:45:51 Resident (Unnamed):** Inquired about sidewalk replacements on Elm Street.
 - *Response:* Mayor Ridenour discussed constraints on sidewalk funding, noting 236 ADA-compliant sidewalk sections completed citywide and ongoing concrete crew scheduling by the city engineer.
- **00:49:51 Resident (Unnamed):** Asked about the timeline for reopening the White River Greenway bridge.
 - *Response:* Mayor Ridenour and staff explained that replacing the old bridge with a single-base design saves the Sanitary District/ratepayers \$1.5 million by reducing flood levy height requirements downriver. The new bridge is projected to open around May 2023, followed by the demolition of the old bridge.

5. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - 26 remote workers have relocated to Muncie.
 - Future “Dream with Dan” sessions will occur monthly.
- **Adjournment:** The meeting concluded naturally following closing remarks from Mayor Ridenour thanking neighborhood president Bruce Rector, city staff, and attending residents **00:55:03**.